

Sederunt principes (The Princes Sat); Alleluia Pascha nostrum (Alleluia, Our Passover [Easter hymn]); dates unknown

Guillaume de Machaut

c. 1300–1377, FRENCH

A poet as well as a composer, Machaut was one of the outstanding cultural figures of his time, employed by various royal and noble patrons and with a reputation that extended through much of Europe. A large amount of his music survives (well over 100 works), much more than for any other composer of the 14th century.

Although he held various minor positions in the Church, most of his music is secular (the main exception is his Mass of Our Lady, the first surviving complete Mass setting by a single composer). He is most famous for his songs, many on the theme of courtly love. They introduced a new variety and complexity into the genre. Machaut traveled a good deal, but he lived mainly in Reims.

KEY WORKS: “Rose, liz, printemps, verdure” (“Rose, Lily, Spring, Greenery”), c. 1340s; Messe de Nostre Dame (Mass of Our Lady), c. 1360; “Ma fin est mon